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United States Patent	12399559
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	August 26, 2025
Inventor(s)	Ben-Yishai; Rani et al.

Optical see through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system and method for precise alignment of virtual objects with outwardly viewed objects

Abstract

A method for irradiating an image in an optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) for viewing through, the OST HMD by a user's eye, an object having at least one of known orientation and position and orientation (O/P&O), associated with a first reference frame, the method comprising: generating and irradiating said image for appearing to said user superimposed in an aligned manner to said object, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and said O/P&O; said predetermined information relates correction data with a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position of said eye; said predetermined information further includes display corrections of said electro-optical display module with respect to said position data values of said at least one eyeball feature position, with respect to a second reference frame; and said O/P&O is between said second reference and said first reference frame.

Inventors:	Ben-Yishai; Rani (Haifa, IL), Benesh; Gil (Haifa, IL)
Applicant:	ELBIT SYSTEMS LTD (Haifa, IL)
Family ID:	1000008782194
Assignee:	ELBIT SYSTEMS LTD. (Haifa, IL)
Appl. No.:	18/783139
Filed:	July 24, 2024

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20250021159 A1	Jan. 16, 2025

Related U.S. Application Data

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **G06F3/01** (20060101); **G02B27/01** (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **G06F3/013** (20130101); **G02B27/0172** (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: G06F (3/011); G06F (3/012); G06F (3/013); G02B (27/0093); G02B (27/0172); G02B (2027/011); G02B (2027/014); G02B (2027/0187); A61B (90/50); A61B (2017/00216); A61B (2034/258); A61B (2090/365); A61B (2090/502); H04N (13/327); H04N (13/344)

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Primary Examiner: Lubit; Ryan A

Attorney, Agent or Firm: Merchant & Gould P.C.

Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) The present application is a Continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 18/557,618, filed Oct. 27, 2023, which is a National Stage Filing of PCT International Application No. PCT/IL2021/050485 filed on Apr. 27, 2021, both of which are incorporated herein by reference in their entirety.

FIELD OF THE DISCLOSED TECHNIQUE

(1) The disclosed technique relates to electro-optical systems and methods, in general, and to optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) systems and methods, in particular.

BACKGROUND OF THE DISCLOSED TECHNIQUE

(2) An optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD), in general is a wearable display device designed to be coupled with a head of a user that is capable of projecting images for viewing by the user while also permitting the user to see through at least part of it. A variety of OST HMD's are known in the art.

(3) U.S. Patent Application Publication No.: US 2014/0078023 A1 to Ikeda et al. entitled "Display Device, Image Processing Device and Image Processing Method, and Computer Program" is directed to an image display system for correcting distortions of images caused by a state of a user, particularly when lens centers of eyepiece optical systems do not match the center positions of the eyes of the user. This mismatch causes at least part of a displayed image to appear distorted, or for each primary color R (red), G (green), B (blue) to appear shifted in at least part of a screen due to the magnification of chromatic aberrations of the lenses. The image display system includes a head-mount unit, a video reduction unit, a distortion correction unit, a correction vector retaining unit, a display unit, and an eyepiece optical system. The head-mount unit includes an eye interval adjusting mechanism, and independent display units for the left eye and the right eye of the user. Video reduction unit processes input video signals to be reduced so that the video signals are appropriate for the size of a display panel.

(4) A distortion correction vector is created in advance according to an amount of shift between the lens centers of the eyepiece optical system and the center position of the eye of the user. Particularly, the distortion correction vector is used to correct magnified chromatic aberrations caused by mismatch of an interval that is smaller than a minimum unit correcting interval of the eye interval adjusting mechanism. The correction vector retaining unit stores the distortion correction vector that is created in advance. Eye interval adjusting mechanism adjusts a position of the display unit(s) with respect to the eye interval of a user in stages. After eye interval adjusting mechanism adjusts the eye interval as much as possible and the distortion correction unit corrects an image according to the correction vector, the distortion correction unit corrects distortion such that position adjustments smaller than the minimum unit correcting interval are interpolated. Particularly, the distortion correction unit corrects the displayed image based on the correction vector according to an amount of shift that remains after the eye interval adjusting mechanism performs the adjustment. The distortion correction unit thus functions to correct input images from the video reduction unit based on the correction vector according to mismatch of a lens center of the eyepiece optical system with the center position of an eye of the user.

(5) U.S. Patent Application Publication No.: US 2011/0187844 A1 to Owaga et al. entitled "Image Irradiation System and Image Irradiation Method" is directed to an image irradiation system and method for generating and projecting images containing information toward a driver of a vehicle without requiring the driver to widely change his/her point of view. The image irradiation system includes a photographing device, a central processing module, a memory device, and an irradiation device. The photographing device includes a first camera and a second camera. The central processing module includes an image signal creation module, a first, second and third position calculation modules, an irradiation position decision module, a drive control module, and a distortion correction module. The photographing device, the irradiation device and the memory device are connected with the central processing module. The first camera is installed facing the driver for taking face photographs, while the second camera is installed above the driver for taking photographs of a head portion. The first position calculation module detects a single eye of the driver for every image inputted from the first camera. The first position calculation module calculates the position of the eye of the driver in a YZ surface perpendicular to the traveling direction of the vehicle. The irradiation position decision module decides a position at which the image is irradiated, based on the position of the eye. The drive control module outputs a control signal to a drive module such that the image is irradiated to an irradiation position determined by the irradiation position decision module.

(6) The second position calculation module detects a center position of the head portion of the driver, as well as the position of the eye on the XY surface. The third position calculation module calculates the position of the eye of the user in an XYZ space based on the eye position on the YZ and XY surfaces, so as to input this position to the image signal creation module. The image creation module creates a projection image of fender poles at the position of the eye, based on corresponding relationship between the calculated eye position and position information of the fender poles. The memory device stores the positions of fender poles, which are installed on the leading edge of the vehicle. The created image signal is inputted to the distortion correction module. The distortion correction module corrects the image signal inputted from the image signal creation module based on the distortion correction information which is read from and stored in the memory device.

(7) An article by Itoh, Y. and Klinker, G. entitled "Interaction-Free Calibration for Optical See-Through Head-Mounted Displays based on 3D Eye Localization" is directed at an interaction-free calibration method for OST-HMDs that utilizes three-dimensional (3-D) eye localization. The method utilizes 3-D eye position measurements acquired from an eye tracker in combination with pre-computed, static display calibration parameters. The eye tracker is rigidly attached to the bottom rim of an HMD, and is oriented towards one of the eyes of a user. A second camera

determines the HMD pose within the surrounding world environment. An offline calibration process determines the rigid setup of the two cameras and the HMD. The HMD is mounted on the user's head. The method generates world-related augmentations in a moving HMD on the user's head, by combining static HMD calibration with dynamic eye tracking. The results of the study described in the article claim that the proposed calibration method with eye tracking is more stable than repeated single point active alignment method (SPAAM) calibrations.

SUMMARY OF THE PRESENT DISCLOSED TECHNIQUE

(8) It is an object of the disclosed technique to provide a novel method and optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system for providing precise alignment between a projected virtual object viewed by a user of an OST HMD and an optically see-through externally viewed object (e.g., real-world or virtual), such that the projected virtual object appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to the external object that is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user through the OST HMD. In accordance with the disclosed technique, there is thus provided an OST HMD system, for viewing an object associated with a first reference frame. The OST HMD system includes an electro-optical display module, and a processor. The electro-optical display module includes at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element, and at least one electro-optical projection module. The partially reflective partially transmissive optical element is configured for at least one of viewing therethrough the object, and viewing the image, by the user. The at least one electro-optical projection module is configured to irradiate the image for viewing by at least one eye of a user who wears the OST HMD. The electro-optical display module is associated with a second reference frame. The processor is configured to be coupled with the electro-optical display module. The processor is configured to generate the image, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, so that the image appears to the user in an aligned manner with respect to the object. The eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye of the user, with respect to the second reference frame. The at least one of orientation and position and orientation of the second reference frame is of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The predetermined information relates correction data of the OST HMD to a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position. The object is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user through the at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element when the image is irradiated by the at least one optical projection module.

(9) According to accessorized implementations or configurations of the disclosed technique, the OST HMD system may further include a position determination module, a tracking system, and a memory device. The position determination module, the tracking system, and the memory device are configured to be communicatively coupled with the processor. The position determination module is configured to determine the at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye with respect to the second reference frame, and to generate the corresponding eyeball feature position data. The tracking system is configured to determine the at least one orientation, and a position and orientation, of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The memory device is configured to store predetermined information relating correction data of the OST HMD to a plurality of different respective position data values of the at least one eyeball feature position.

(10) In accordance with another aspect of the disclosed technique there is thus provided a method for irradiating an image in an OST HMD for viewing through the OST HMD an object associated with a first reference frame, by at least one eye of a user. The method includes generating and irradiating the image for viewing by the user, such that the image appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to the object that is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation. The

predetermined information relates correction data of the OST HMD with a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position of the at least one eye. The eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye, with respect to a second reference frame. The at least one of orientation and position and orientation is of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The object is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user. The method may further include a procedure of generating the eyeball feature position data by determining corresponding at least one eyeball feature position. The method may further include a procedure of determining the at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) The disclosed technique will be understood and appreciated more fully from the following detailed description taken in conjunction with the drawings in which:
- (2) FIG. 1A is a schematic illustration of an optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system, showing a particular mounting configuration on a user, constructed and operative in accordance with an embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (3) FIG. 1B is a schematic illustration of the OST HMD system, showing another mounting configuration on the user, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (4) FIG. 2 is a top-level schematic block diagram of the OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (5) FIG. 3 is a schematic illustration showing high-level configuration and operation aspects of the OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (6) FIG. 4 is a schematic block diagram of an OST HMD calibration system, associated with OST HMD system of FIG. 2, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (7) FIG. 5A is a schematic diagram showing a first phase in a calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (8) FIG. 5B is a schematic diagram showing a second phase in the calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (9) FIG. 5C is a schematic diagram showing a third phase in the calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;
- (10) FIGS. 6A-6E show the fourth phase of the calibration procedure, and specifically:
- (11) FIG. 6A is a schematic illustration showing the effect of not correcting the eye position of a user, and OST aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations;
- (12) FIG. 6B is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting the eye position of a user, but not correcting for OST aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations;
- (13) FIG. 6C is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting for eye position of a user, and OST aberration correction, but not of correcting for electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations;
- (14) FIG. 6D is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting for the eye position of a user, OST aberration correction, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner

aberrations;

(15) FIG. 6E is a schematic block diagram illustrating a representation of the unified correction data in the form of a lookup table;

(16) FIG. 7 is a schematic block diagram of a method, illustrating steps in the initial calibration procedure, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(17) FIG. 8A is a schematic diagram showing various parts of an eye of a user, referred in the context of the disclosed technique;

(18) FIG. 8B is a schematic diagram showing an acquired image of the eye shown in FIG. 8A, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(19) FIG. 8C is a schematic illustration showing use of unified correction data for providing real-time alignment between a projected virtual object on optical combiner and a real-world object as viewed by an eye of a user, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(20) FIG. 8D is a schematic illustration showing orientation correction of a projected image with respect to a rotated orientation of OST HMD;

(21) FIG. 9 is a schematic block diagram illustrating the steps of a method, constructed and operative in accordance with the disclosed technique;

(22) FIG. 10A is a schematic illustration of a partial block diagram of an OST HMD system, showing an integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module, constructed and operative in accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(23) FIG. 10B is a schematic illustration of an example implementation of the integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module, of FIG. 10A in greater detail;

(24) FIG. 10C is a schematic illustration showing a high-level configuration and operation aspects of the OST HMD system of FIG. 10A;

(25) FIG. 11A is a schematic illustration showing another optical configuration of electro-optical projection module and eye position determination module, constructed and operative in accordance with a further embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(26) FIG. 11B is a schematic illustration showing the optical configuration of FIG. 11A in greater detail;

(27) FIG. 12A is a schematic illustration showing a side-view arrangement, of OST HMD, having multiple eye position determination modules, constructed and operative in accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique;

(28) FIG. 12B is a schematic illustration showing a partial forward facing view of OST HMD of FIG. 12A;

(29) FIG. 13A is a schematic illustration of an example implementation of the disclosed technique in a surgery setting, targeting a hidden object that is an internal body part of a subject; and

(30) FIG. 13B is a schematic illustration of the surgery setting of FIG. 13A, showing a projected image of the hidden internal body part of the subject being superimposed in an aligned manner with a corresponding position of the hidden internal body part of the subject.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE EMBODIMENTS

(31) The disclosed technique overcomes the disadvantages of the prior art by providing a method and optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system that enable precise alignment between a projected virtual object viewed by a user of the OST HMD and an externally viewed object (e.g., real-world or virtual object such as the horizon, a virtual image, etc.), such that the projected virtual object appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to the external object appearing outwardly to the user through the OST HMD. The OST displays of the disclosed technique may be based on technologies such as visor projection, combiners, waveguide techniques (e.g., microstructure extraction, diffractive optics or holograms, micro-mirror beam-splitters, polarization reflection techniques), retinal scanning, on-pupil optics or contact lenses, and

the like. Among various types of HMDs, the disclosed technique involves HMDs that include at least an electro-optical display module, and a partially reflective partially transmissive optical element. A general overview of the system and method of the disclosed technique now follows.

(32) In accordance with the disclosed technique, there is thus provided an OST HMD system, for viewing an object associated with a first reference frame. The OST HMD system includes an electro-optical display module, and a processor. The electro-optical display module includes at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element for viewing the object therethrough, and at least one electro-optical projection module configured to irradiate an image for viewing by at least one eye of a user who wears the OST HMD. The processor is configured to be coupled with the electro-optical display module. The processor is configured to generate the image, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, so that the image appears to the user in an aligned manner with respect to the object. The eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye of the user, with respect to the second reference frame. The at least one of orientation and position and orientation of the second reference frame is of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The predetermined information relates correction data of the OST HMD to a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position. The object is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user through the at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element when the image is irradiated by the at least one optical projection module.

(33) According to accessorized implementations or configurations of the disclosed technique, the OST HMD system may further include a position determination module, a tracking system, and optionally a memory device. The position determination module is configured to determine the at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye with respect to the second reference frame, and to generate the corresponding eyeball feature position data. According to one example implementation, the position determination module is an eye tracker integrated into the OST HMD system. The tracking system is configured to determine at least one of: (1) orientation, and (2) a position and orientation, of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The memory device is configured to store predetermined information relating correction data of the OST HMD to a plurality of different respective position data values of the at least one eyeball feature position.

(34) In accordance with another aspect of the disclosed technique there is thus provided a method for irradiating an image in an OST HMD for viewing through the OST HMD an object associated with a first reference frame, by at least one eye of a user. The method includes a procedure of generating and irradiating the image for viewing by the user, such that the image appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to the object that is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation. The predetermined information relates correction data of the OST HMD with a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position of the at least one eye. The eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye, with respect to a second reference frame. The at least one of orientation and position and orientation is of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. The object is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user. The method may further include a procedure of generating eyeball feature position data by determining corresponding at least one eyeball feature position. The method may further include a procedure of determining the at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. Without loss of generality, the at least one of orientation, and position and orientation is selected to be described herein from a perspective of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame, however, the

reverse perspective wherein the at least one of orientation, and position and orientation of first reference frame is with respect to the second reference frame is likewise viable and applicable to the disclosed technique.

(35) The following is a top-level description of the disclosed technique, which is followed by a more detailed, low-level description. Reference is now made to FIGS. 1A, 1B and 2. FIG. 1A is a schematic illustration of an optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system, generally referenced **100**, showing a particular mounting configuration on a user, constructed and operative in accordance with an embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 1B is a schematic illustration of the OST HMD system, showing another mounting configuration on the user, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 2 is a top-level schematic block diagram of the OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 1A shows a general mounting configuration of OST HMD system **100** onto a head **12** of a user **10** utilizing at least one head coupler **101** (also referred interchangeably herein as “HMD-to-head coupler”, helmet, or “harness”). Head coupler **101** is configured and operative to couple OST HMD system **100** firmly with at least a part of head **12** of user **10** so as to provide minimal movement between OST HMD system **100** and head **12**, especially when head **12** moves. Head coupler **101** may typically be configured and constructed to be in the form of two longitudinal stems each extending from the two (i.e., right and left) sides of head **12**. An alternative configuration and construction of head coupler **101** may take the form of a helmet as shown in FIG. 1B, configured to at least partially cover head **12** of user **10**, as well as to provide protection to head **12** (i.e., from impact, injury, external environment, etc.). Other alternative configurations and constructions (not shown) of head coupler **101** include those utilizing a strap (e.g., a flexible adjustable strap) or straps (head and chin straps), a headband, overhead straps (e.g., having various configurations such as extending longitudinally, crosswise, etc.), and the like.

(36) With reference to FIG. 2, OST HMD system **100** is configured and operative to be implemented in four disparate and separate main configurations: (1) a basic configuration; (2) a first accessorized configuration; (3) a second accessorized configuration; and (4) a fully accessorized configuration. According to the basic configuration, OST HMD system **100** includes a processor **102**, electro-optical display module **110**, and optionally a memory device **104**. The first accessorized configuration additionally includes (i.e., with respect to the basic configuration), a tracking system **106**. The second accessorized configuration additionally includes (i.e., with respect to the basic configuration), an eye position determination module **108**. The fully accessorized configuration includes all components of the basic configuration, the first accessorized configuration, the second accessorized configuration, as well as the following optional peripheral components: a user interface **116**, an input/output (I/O) interface **118**, and a communication module **120**. Memory device **104** may optionally be included in each of the four aforementioned configurations (1)-(4). Optional peripheral components, namely, user interface **116**, I/O interface **118**, and communication module **120** may be included in each of aforementioned configurations (1)-(4). The first accessorized configuration (i.e., “configuration (2)”) is denoted herein as “tracking-system-included, eye-position-determination-module-excluded configuration”. The second accessorized configuration (i.e., configuration (3)”) is denoted herein as “eye-position-determination-module-included, tracking-system-excluded configuration”.

(37) Electro-optical display module **110** includes an electro-optical projection module **112**, and an optical combiner **114** (also referred interchangeably herein as “partially reflective partially transmissive optical element”). Processor **102** is configured to be coupled with the following components in accordance with the aforementioned configurations (1)-(4): memory device **104**, tracking system **106**, eye position determination module **108**, electro-optical display module **110**, user interface **116**, I/O interface **118**, and with communication module **120**. Tracking system **106** may include a plurality of distinct units (e.g., **106.sub.1** (described in conjunction with FIG. 3), and

the like). Tracking system **106**, eye position determination module **108**, and electro-optical projection module **112** collectively form what is hereinafter termed as the “optical assembly”. (In the basic configuration, the optical assembly includes electro-optical projection module **112**, but not tracking system **106**, and eye position determination module **108**.) The individual components of the optical assembly have fixed relative positions to each other (e.g., typically mechanically coupled to an enclosure or housing). For example, electro-optical display module **110** and eye position determination module **108** are mechanically coupled. The position and orientation of the optical assembly may assume various interchangeable arrangements (not shown) with respect to HMD-to-head coupler **101**. During operation of OST HMD system **101** the optical assembly is mostly fixed with respect to HMD-to-head coupler **101**.

(38) As will be described in greater detail hereinbelow, according to the basic configuration, processor **102** is configured and operative to receive eyeball feature position data associated with at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye of the user with respect to the second reference frame, as well as to receive at least one of the orientation and a position and orientation of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame. Alternatively, processor **102** possesses (e.g., is preprogrammed, has stored in internal memory, program, firmware thereof, etc.) at least one of the eyeball feature position data, and the at least one of the orientation, and position and orientation of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame.

(39) Processor **102** is configured to receive the eyeball feature position data from a user (such as a technician measuring the eyeball feature position or from a known database/measurement) using user interface **118**. Alternatively, processor **102** is configured to receive the eyeball feature position data via communication module **116** (e.g., from the Internet, database, remote computer, technician, the user him/her/it-self, and the like). Further alternatively, processor **102** is configured to receive the eyeball feature position data from memory device **104**. Further alternatively, processor **102** is configured to receive the eyeball feature position data from software, an algorithm, at least one medium capable of storing data and instructions executed by processor **102**, and the like.

Alternatively, processor **102** is configured and operative to receive the eyeball feature position data via an external eye position determination system (e.g., an eye-tracking system, such as an optical tracker, a contact lens type eye tracker, etc.) (not shown) that is not part of OST HMD system **100**.

The external eye position determination module is configured to generate the eyeball feature position data and provide it to OST HMD system **100** (e.g., to processor **102**, to memory device **104**). According to one implementation, the eyeball feature position data is provided during a calibration stage by projecting an image to a user to be aligned with a real-world object (e.g., a jig), whereby the user can repeatedly update the eyeball feature position data, which in turn processor **102** uses to generate the image, until it appears aligned with the object. Alternatively, the external eye position determination module and/or memory device **104** are configured to save eye position data inputted by the user to be retrieved by processor **102** for future use. Further alternatively, according to another implementation employing calibration for producing the eyeball feature position data, the calibration procedure produces a calibration set (not shown) of eyeball feature position data in which the user can indicate or select (i.e., input into OST HMD system **100**) a user-preferred or user-selected eyeball feature position. It is noted, for example that the user-selected eyeball feature position may not necessarily be an actual eyeball feature position but rather an “effective eye position” for which OST HMD system **100** generates an aligned image when the user looks at a calibration jig (not shown) or calibration object (not shown). The eyeball feature position data can be user-selected based on a subjective view of the user, can be based on trial and error, as well as derived information and indirect measurement of the eyeball feature position itself (e.g., based on information pertaining to the position of at least one other body feature (e.g., nose contour) of the user and that latter body feature position in relation to the eyeball feature).

(40) In the case of OST HMD system **100** receiving the eyeball feature position data from a calibration process, one implementation involves continuous use of OST HMD system **100**

immediately after receiving eyeball feature position data from the calibration process (i.e., OST HMD system **100** is not shut down or turned off after receiving the eyeball feature position data). One option is that the calibration process for providing the eyeball feature position data is performed once when the OST HMD system **100** is turned on. Another option is that the calibration process is repeated at any time when there is a need to do so (e.g., there is a degradation of accuracy, such as when the HMD is shifted with respect to the head of the user). Alternatively, in case the HMD is positioned on the head of a user in a repetitive manner for the same user, memory device **104** is configured to store the user-specific calibration result (i.e., user-specific eyeball feature position data) such that it is associated with that user. Both alternatives may be useful for the same user of OST HMD system **100**, for example when using OST HMD system **100** for visor-guided surgery (VGS). VGS is based on tracking and augmented reality. In VGS procedures performed with a VGS system, the HMD augments a surgeon's view of a patient thereby enabling the surgeon to view anatomical features (e.g., anatomical structures), surgical tools, implants, and other virtual objects as if the patient's body were partially transparent. Some of these procedures may require basic accuracy for which one-time calibration accuracy may be sufficient (i.e., even if the HMD is mounted on the head of the user in a slightly different position every time it is used). Other procedures may require very high accuracy and in those cases the user may perform calibration just prior to use of OST HMD system **100** without moving the HMD between calibration and use. An example for a VGS procedure that may require basic accuracy is a craniotomy, and an example for a VGS procedure that may require high accuracy is a biopsy of a small and deeply located brain tumor.

(41) Further according to the basic configuration, processor **102** is configured and operative to receive the at least one of (1) orientation and (2) position and orientation, of the second reference frame with respect to the first reference frame via an external tracking system (not shown) that is not part of OST HMD system **100**. Such a tracking system may be installed at an area, site, and space, where the user is located or intended to be located (e.g., a vehicle such as a cockpit of an aircraft, part of a building, an outdoor area, etc.). Optionally, at least part of such a tracking system (e.g., active and/or passive markers, sensors, and the like) is located on the OST HMD. Example tracking systems include optical tracking systems and methods employing optical detectors (e.g., cameras) that employ computer vision algorithms, electromagnetic (EM) tracking systems and methods employing EM field generation and corresponding EM sensors.

(42) The first accessorized configuration additionally includes (with respect to the basic configuration), tracking system **106**, which will be elaborated on hereinbelow. Furthermore, tracking system **106**, which is an integral part of the first accessorized configuration, can be implemented by the example techniques specified above (e.g., optical tracking, EM tracking, computer vision algorithms, and the like).

(43) The second accessorized configuration further includes (with respect to the basic configuration), eye position determination module **108**, which will be elaborated on hereinbelow. Furthermore, eye position determination module **108** can be implemented by the techniques specified above. According to one implementation, eye position determination module **108** is configured to output eyeball feature position data from time to time (e.g., a scheduled manner, when there's a requirement due to changing conditions and/or users, etc.). Alternatively, eye position determination module **108** is configured to output eyeball feature position data continuously (e.g., in real-time using a real-time eye-tracker).

(44) In the following description, any mentioned component with its corresponding function is associated with a configuration (i.e., among (1)-(4)) that includes that component. For example, an embodiment that includes a tracking system is applicable to the first accessorized configuration (2). An embodiment that includes an eye position determination module is applicable to the second accessorized configuration (3). An embodiment that includes both tracking system and eye position determination module is applicable to the fully accessorized configuration (4). An embodiment that

excludes both tracking system and eye position determination module is applicable to the basic configuration (1).

(45) Reference is now further made to FIG. 3, which is a schematic illustration showing high-level configuration and operation aspects of the OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 3 illustrates OST HMD system **100** mounted onto user **10** via HMD-to-user coupler **101** that assumes a general form of a helmet (i.e., referred herein interchangeably, and without loss of generality as “helmet **101**”). OST HMD system **100** enables user **10** to view an object **140** that is located at a distance from user **10** and appears to the user outwardly through partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**. OST HMD system **100** is associated with an optical assembly reference frame **122** (also denoted interchangeably herein as “HMD reference frame **122**”), shown representatively in FIG. 3 as a 3-dimensional (3-D) Cartesian coordinate system whose axes are denoted by convention (X.sup.H,Y.sup.H,Z.sup.H), where the ‘H’ superscript signifies HMD for brevity. Analogously, object **140** is associated with an object reference frame **142**, shown representatively in FIG. 3 as a 3-D Cartesian coordinate system whose axes are denoted by convention (X.sup.O,Y.sup.O,Z.sup.O), where the ‘O’ superscript signifies, and is brevity for, ‘Object’. Object **140** may have at least one of a known position and a known orientation with respect to object reference frame **142**, indicated generally by (x.sup.O,y.sup.O,z.sup.O) denoting position and (α .sup.O, β .sup.O, γ .sup.O) denoting orientation (e.g., via Euler angles, axis-angle representation, etc.). An example for object **140** having only a known position is a point-like object (e.g., point light source). An example for object **140** having only a known orientation is the horizon (in which case the object coordinate system can be chosen arbitrarily, for example Earth's coordinate (longitude, latitude, altitude)). Preferably (but without loss of generality in the selection of a coordinate system), the system and method of the disclosed technique employ (for applications involving piloting of aircraft) a local-level, local-north (LLLN) coordinate system (also known in the art as a north-east-down (NED) coordinate system, also known as local tangent plane (LTP) coordinate system). Particular positions and orientations are denoted herein by subscripts. For example, a particular position (e.g., position ‘1’) of object **140** in object reference frame **142** is denoted by (x.sub.1.sup.o,y.sub.1.sup.o,z.sub.1.sup.o), and a particular orientation (e.g., orientation ‘1’) of the object is denoted by (α .sub.1.sup.o, β .sub.1.sup.o, γ .sub.1.sup.o). Without loss of generality, the 3-D Cartesian coordinate system is chosen as a basis for describing the principles disclosed technique, however, it is noted that alternative coordinate systems, conventions, and formalisms may be used to indicate position and describe particulars of the disclosed technique, for example, generalized coordinates and the like.

(46) FIG. 3 further shows the optical assembly including at least a part of tracking system **106** (a tracking system unit denoted by **106.sub.1**), eye position determination module **108**, and electro-optical projection module **112** being arranged in fixed relative positions and orientations with respect to helmet **101**, according to one example arrangement. According to one (simple) implementation, the position of the optical assembly is known with respect to eye **14** of user **10**. According to another (typical) implementation, the position of the optical assembly with respect to eye **14** is not known a priori. In such a case it may be advantageous to define a particular point in optical assembly reference frame **122** as the “nominal eye position” (or design eye position (DEP)) which is an approximate position of an average eye.

(47) Electro-optical projection module **112** is configured and operative to irradiate and to project light encoded with information (e.g., an image) for viewing by at least one eye **14** of user **10** wearing OST HMD system **100** (as shown in FIG. 1). Specifically, electro-optical projection module **112** emits light beams that are typically encoded with information, diagrammatically represented by a light ray **124** (FIG. 3), that impinge and at least partially reflect from partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** toward eye **14** of user **10**. Partially transmissive partially reflective optical element **114** is configured and operative to allow the

irradiated light to at least partially reflect off its surface toward at least one eye **14** of user **10**, while also concurrently allowing at least partial transmission therethrough of incoming light from the surrounding or forward-facing physical environment viewed by the user (diagrammatically represented by incoming light ray **126**). In effect, partially transmissive partially reflective optical element **114** is configured and operative as an optical combiner that enables the irradiated light encoded with information (e.g., a virtual object) to be superimposed (overlaid) over a viewed scene of the physical environment, the particulars of which will be described hereinbelow. The irradiated light encoded with information is typically an image **144** that is formed and is reflected off partially reflective surface of partially transmissive partially reflective optical element **114**. In general, partially transmissive partially reflective optical element **114** (i.e., “optical combiner **114**” for brevity) is typically composed of a combination of sub-elements that include a strong, durable, impact-resistant primary material (e.g., polycarbonate), that is substantially optically transparent (e.g., in the visible part of the EM spectrum), as well as one or plurality of thin film reflection coating(s), etc. Electro-optical projection module **112** may be embodied in the form of a micro-display, a near-eye display, and the like.

(48) Eye position determination module **108** is configured and operative to determine at least one eyeball feature position associated with at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14** of user **10** wearing OST HMD **100**, and to generate corresponding eyeball feature position data. The term “eyeball feature” refers herein to any detectable (e.g., optically) feature of the eyeball of the user, such as the pupil, iris, blood vessels, limbus, etc. The term “eyeball feature position” refers herein to at least a partial position (e.g., a 2-D position without depth) of an eyeball feature with respect to a reference frame. Alternatively, an eyeball feature position of a corresponding eyeball feature can include 3-D feature position information. The term “eyeball feature position data” refers to data pertaining to eyeball feature position (e.g., 2-D eyeball feature position data, 3-D eyeball feature position data, a location of an eyeball feature present in an image of at least part of the eyeball), or derivative data (e.g., indirect measurement data) pertaining to the position of the eyeball feature or data that can be used to derive the eyeball feature position data (e.g., via a mathematical relation). It is noted that according to one implementation, the exact knowledge of the eyeball feature position within reference frame **122** is not necessary. For example, eye position determination module **108** determines eyeball feature position data in an acquired image of the eyeball feature that is associated with the eyeball feature position (not determined). The disclosed technique is configured and operative to associate the determined eyeball feature position data with respective correction data. Eye position determination module **108** is further configured and operative to provide (e.g., transmit) the eyeball feature position data to processor **102** (FIG. 2). In accordance with one configuration, eye position determination module **108** includes hardware (e.g., an internal processor) that is configured to determine eyeball feature position data and generate corresponding eyeball feature position data. In accordance with another configuration, eye position determination module **108** detects eyeball features and provides data (e.g., raw, unprocessed) pertaining to those detected features to processor **102**, which in turn determines at least one eyeball feature position from data received from eye position determination module **108**. According to one implementation, eye position determination module **108** includes at least one camera configured to acquire at least one image of at least one eyeball feature. According to other implementations, eye position determination module **108** includes at least one optical sensor (e.g., a photo-detector), a combination of optical sensors and light sources (e.g., infrared (IR) light emitting diodes (LEDs), light beam scanning devices (e.g., incorporating microelectromechanical systems (MEMS) and lasers), and the like. Eye position determination module **108** may include several components integrated into one unit. Alternatively, eye position determination module **108** may include several components separated apart (e.g., an optical sensor located at a distance from a light source such as an IR LED). According to another implementation, there are multiple eye position determination modules, the specifics of which will be described in greater detail hereinbelow in conjunction with

FIGS. 12A and 12B.

(49) Memory device **104** (FIG. 2) is configured and operative to store predetermined information relating correction data of OST HMD (including electro-optical display module **110** that includes optical combiner **114** (having particular optical characteristics) and electro-optical projection module **112**) to a plurality of different respective position data values of corresponding at least one eyeball feature position. Memory device **104** enables retrieval of the predetermined information stored therein. Specifically, memory device **104** stores predetermined information that associates correction data (e.g., generated by a calibration method) of optical combiner **114** and electro-optical display module **110** with a plurality of different respective position data values of corresponding at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14** of user **10** (i.e., this association as well as the calibration method are described in detail hereinbelow in the low-level description of the disclosed technique). A non-limiting example of a preferred eyeball feature position is a center position of a pupil of eye **14**. Alternatively, memory device **104** is embodied in at least one implementation that includes being a part of an internal memory of processor **102** (FIG. 2), firmware of processor **102**, and software configured to be run by processor **102**. Further alternatively, memory device **104** is located away and separate from processor **102** (e.g., an external storage database such as in the cloud, an external data storage device(s), an external computer, a computer network, and the like). For example, memory device **104** can be incorporated into the electronics of a user's HMD (e.g., pilot's helmet) that is enabled to store calibration data, (e.g., predetermined information), user-specific calibration data, manufacturing data, etc., as well as to connect to OST HMD **100** (e.g., during calibration, initialization, routine function, etc.). Alternatively, processor **102** is installed the electronics of a vehicle such as an aircraft and memory device **104** incorporated into the user's HMD (e.g., pilot's helmet). According to this alternative, once there's an established a connection between the pilot's HMD and the aircraft's electronics, the processor in the aircraft (e.g., during initialization, re-calibration, etc.) reads the calibration data from the HMD. Processor **102** (whether installed in at least one of the aircraft, and the HMD), is configured to store the user-specific calibration data (e.g., for each vehicle operator such as pilot, driver, etc.), that is associated with that user (e.g., identifiable via the manufacturing data such as the HMD's serial number). Note that processor **102** may include of a plurality of processing sub-units (not shown), integrated together. Alternatively the plurality of processing sub-units may be located away from each other (not shown) (e.g., part of processor **102**, e.g., at least one processing sub-unit is located in user's HMD, and at least one other processing sub-unit is located in a vehicle operated by that user (e.g., aircraft, land vehicle, sea vessel, etc.). Further note that memory device **104** may include a plurality of memory sub-units (not shown), which can be integrated together. Alternatively, at least part of the memory sub-units is located away from each other (not shown).

(50) The term “optical characteristic” referenced herein either in singular or in plural, ascribed or pertaining to a particular object, refers to any attribute, quality, trait, property and phenomenon in the science of optics that optically defines, influences, characterizes, determines, describes, and is associated with that object. Example optical characteristics of optical combiner **114**, include the diopter, refractive index, curvature, Abbe number, power error(s), optical element (e.g., lens) induced astigmatism, transmission coefficient, reflection coefficient, spectral (e.g., ultraviolet) cutoff wavelength, spectral transmission and reflection profile, lens dimensions (e.g., thickness), lens color (e.g., color-tinted), etc.

(51) Tracking system **106** (FIG. 2) is configured and operative to determine at least one of: (1) a position, and (2) an orientation, i.e., position or orientation, or both position and orientation, denoted interchangeably as “position and/or orientation” of optical assembly reference frame **122** with respect to object reference frame **142** (FIG. 3). At least one of tracking system **106** and processor **102** is configured to determine (e.g., calculate) the position and/or orientation. Alternatively, at least one of tracking system **106**, memory device **104**, and processor **102** is configured to store the position and/or orientation. Alternatively, tracking system **106** may

determine position and/or orientation of object **140** with respect to optical assembly reference frame **122**. Hence, tracking system **106** determines the position and/or orientation of head **12** of user **10** wearing helmet **101** with respect to the position ($x_{sub.1.sup.o}, y_{sub.1.sup.o}, z_{sub.1.sup.o}$) and orientation ($\alpha_{sub.1.sup.o}, \beta_{sub.1.sup.o}, \gamma_{sub.1.sup.o}$) of object **140**. For example, if user **10** is piloting an aircraft and object **140** is Earth, the orientation ($\alpha_{sub.1.sup.o}, \beta_{sub.1.sup.o}, \gamma_{sub.1.sup.o}$) of head **12** of user **10** with respect to object reference frame **142** may be used to display to the user a horizon line such that it is superimposed on Earth's horizon. The respective positions and/or orientations between tracking system unit **106.sub.1** and other helmet-mounted components of system **100**, such as eye position determination module **108**, electro-optical projection module **112**, and optical combiner **114**, may be known (e.g., via a calibration procedure), given the rigid relative spatial relationship therebetween. In a calibration procedure the positions and/or orientations of eye position determination module **108**, electro-optical projection module **112**, and optical combiner **114** in HMD reference frame **122** may be determined. In the case OST HMD **100** has a substantially collimated optical design, the projected image is theoretically at infinity and the knowledge of the position of electro-optical projection module **112** is not required. In various implementations the position and orientation of eye position determination module **108** is also not required (i.e. in order to generate eyeball feature position data). For example, in various implementations (such as pilot applications) only the orientation of tracking system unit **106.sub.1** relative to electro-optical projection module **112** is required. In other implementations (such as medical applications) there is a need to also perform calibration between tracking system unit **106.sub.1** and eye position determination module **108**. Tracking system **106** typically employs optical methods such as at least one camera (e.g., a stereo camera, two cameras, 3-D optical sensor that generates a 2-D image and an additional depth image), optical projection and photogrammetric methods, electromagnetic (EM) methods, inertial measurement methods, global position system (GPS) methods, and the like. For example, tracking system **106** may be configured as an outside-in optical tracker employing passive optical reflectors on the helmet and sensors in the object reference frame, an inside-out optical tracker employing sensors on the helmet and light sources (e.g., light-emitting-diodes (LEDs)) in the object reference frame, or a combination thereof (e.g., an opto-inertial in-out/out-in tracker). Alternatively, tracking system **106** may be configured and operative as an electromagnetic field tracker in which for example tracking system unit **106.sub.1** (denoted interchangeably herein “tracker unit”) senses the EM field generated by a transmitter located in object reference frame **142** and provides the sensed readings to processor **102** via I/O interface **118** and/or communication module **120**. Tracking system **106** provides the determined position and/or orientation of optical assembly reference frame **122** with respect to object reference frame **142**, to processor **102**.

(52) Processor **102** is configured and operative to generate and provide an image **146** (image data) to electro-optical projection module **112**, based on the output from tracking system **106**, the predetermined information stored in memory device **104**, and eyeball feature position data, so that (irradiated and projected) image **144** appears to user **10** in an aligned manner with respect to object **140** located outwardly from the user through optical combiner **114**, representatively illustrated in FIG. 3 by a superimposed image **148**. Image **146** has been pre-distorted or corrected by processor **102** such that when electro-optical projection module **112** irradiates and projects (irradiated, projected and then partially reflected) image **144** onto optical combiner **114** it is seen aligned with respect to object **140** by user **10**. The terms “aligned”, and “alignment” refer herein to arriving at or being at least one of: matched relative position, matched relative orientation, and matched size (scaling) between an image and a real-world object. For example, an aligned arrangement is an image of a point indicating a location in an object within a body, such as a center of a tumor in the brain (i.e., aligned center-position), an image of a line indicating a horizontal level with respect to a linear object (i.e., aligned orientation), an image of a line indicating the true horizon to an aircraft pilot user (i.e., aligned position and orientation), an image of a symbol indicating the direction to a

target foe aircraft for a pilot (i.e., aligned position), an image of a line indicating a proposed contour of an incision to be made inside or outside the body of a patient (i.e., aligned position, orientation, and scaling), or guidance trajectory of a tool to be inserted to a body (i.e., aligned position and orientation), an image of contours of structures (e.g., buildings, mountains, landmarks, etc. that may be completely or partially hidden to a pilot (e.g., due to fog, or other low visibility conditions (e.g., at night), precisely aligned and superimposed on the real-world structures (i.e., aligned position, orientation, and scaling). In the last example OST HMD system **100** enables to assist a pilot in avoiding collision with these structures. Further examples in the medical realm include a 3-D image segmentation of a body part or tissue constructed and/or rendered from medical imagery (e.g. of a tumor in a brain constructed and/or rendered from magnetic resonance imaging (MRI), a vertebra constructed and/or rendered from a computerized tomography (CT) scan), superimposed precisely on a real-world body part or tissue within the body that is hidden to the user when viewed directly. Further examples include a combination of synthetic 3-D objects to be displayed to the user where image data of 3-D objects are derived from different sources, for example image data of a tumor derived from an MRI scan, image data of a skull derived from a CT scan, a tool or implant model derived from 3-D computer-aided design (CAD) (3-D known model), and the like. Processor **102** is optionally further configured to determine the distance (alternatively, receive distance information) between the second reference frame and the real-world object so as to further scale (i.e., determine or adjust the dimensions of) image **146** to correspond with said distance.

(53) Another example is a projected synthetic image superimposed onto a real-world scene containing a hidden object not directly seen by user **10**, such as in a minimally invasive surgery setting, where the hidden object is an internal body part, and the external projected synthetic image is aligned (i.e., overlaid onto corresponding position) with that body part. This implementation of the disclosed technique will be further elaborated hereinbelow in conjunction with FIGS. **13A** and **13B**. FIG. **3** illustrates an alignment between real-world object **140** as seen by user and image **146** that is irradiated, projected and formed on optical combiner **114** as image **144** such that crosshairs of image **146** are matched in terms of position and orientation with respect to position and orientation of object **140**, depicted as a superimposed image **148**. As will be elucidated in a low-level description of the disclosed technique, which follows, alignment is achieved by taking into consideration the following: the position and orientation of the optical assembly with respect to the position and orientation of object **140**, the position of the eye of the user (“eye location”) with respect to the optical assembly, as well as see-through errors depending on eye location such as prismatic effect, aberration (e.g., distortion) effects of partially reflective partially transmissive optical element (e.g., due to its curvature, and other optical characteristics), as well as distortion effects arising from the electro-optical projection module.

(54) A low-level description of the disclosed technique now follows. To achieve alignment, an initial calibration procedure (method) of OST HMD system **100** is performed by a calibration system. Reference is now made to FIG. **4**, which is a schematic block diagram of an OST HMD calibration system, generally referenced **150**, associated with OST HMD system **100** of FIG. **2**, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. OST HMD calibration system **150** includes a calibration processor **152**, a calibration memory unit **154**, a calibration camera **156**, a (calibration) camera multiple-axis actuator **158**, a calibration input/output (I/O) interface **160**, a calibration communication module **162**, a calibration user interface **164**, and an optional platform multiple-axis actuator **166**. Calibration processor **152** is coupled with calibration memory unit **154**, calibration camera **156**, camera multiple-axis actuator **158**, calibration I/O interface **160**, calibration communication module **162**, calibration user interface **164**, and with platform multiple-axis actuator **166**. Calibration memory unit **154** may be further coupled with calibration camera **156** (further configured and operative as a data buffer). Camera multiple-axis actuator **158** is further mechanically coupled with calibration camera **156**. Platform

multiple-axis actuator **150** is further mechanically coupled with at least part of OST HMD calibration system **150**, and helmet **101**. OST HMD calibration system **150** is coupled with OST HMD system **100** (FIG. 2) via I/O interface **160**. Alternatively or additionally, OST HMD calibration system **150** is coupled with OST HMD system **100** via communication module **162**. Further alternatively or further additionally, OST HMD calibration system **150** is coupled with OST HMD system **100** via user interface **164**.

(55) Calibration processor **152** is configured and operative to process data pertaining to the calibration procedure, as will be described hereinbelow in greater detail. The example calibration procedure that is described hereinbelow is an example given to elucidate the general principles of the disclosed technique. Other example calibration procedures may be applicable with the disclosed technique. Generally, calibration camera **156** is configured and operative to acquire at least one image of a calibration object **168** (i.e., physical or synthetic (e.g., projected image)) that is separated by a certain distance from calibration camera **156**. It is noted that the calibration procedure described for the purposes of elucidating the principles of the disclosed technique may not require a calibration object (e.g., such as in a calibration method that employs calibration camera pairs, i.e., two cameras directed at one another). The relative position and orientation of calibration object **168** with respect to the position and orientation of calibration camera **156** may be known (i.e., determined, measured). Calibration memory unit **154** is configured and operative to store data pertaining to the calibration procedure for retrieval. Camera multiple-axis actuator **158** is configured and operative to mechanically move calibration camera **156** to specific positions (i.e., in three spatial axes (X, Y, Z)) with respect to HMD reference frame **122**. By controlling camera multiple-axis actuator **158**, calibration processor **152** controls the position of calibration camera **156** in HMD reference frame **122**. An additional tracker unit (not shown), similar to **106.sub.1** (FIG. 3), may be attached to calibration camera **156**, such that tracking system **106** may be configured to use this additional tracker unit to determine an exact position of calibration camera **156** in HMD reference frame **122** during each stage of the calibration procedure. I/O interface **160** is configured and operative to couple with I/O interface **118** (FIG. 2) of OST HMD system **100**. Communication module **162** is configured and operative to communicate data at least with OST HMD system **100** (e.g., via communication module **120**). User interface **164** is configured and operative to interact with a user (not shown), specifically, to receive user input as well as to provide output (e.g., via a monitor (not shown)).

(56) Now the example calibration procedure will be described in conjunction with FIGS. 5A, 5B, 5C, 6A, 6B, 6C, 6D, and 6E. Without loss of generality, the example calibration procedure is the preferred (default) calibration procedure of the disclosed technique. To further detail the various phases of the calibration procedure, reference is now further made to FIG. 5A, which is a schematic diagram showing a first phase in a calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. The initial phase in the example calibration procedure involves mounting OST HMD system **100** including calibration camera **156**, and calibration object **168** securely on at least one platform (e.g., two platforms **1701** and **1702** are shown in FIG. 5A) such that calibration camera **156** has a direct line-of-sight (LOS) to calibration object **168**, without partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** (provisionally removed) being interposed therebetween.

(57) The first phase of the calibration procedure determines a camera aberration correction data (reference data) **176**, which pertains to various parameters that associate an image of a distant object acquired by a calibration camera in at least one camera position and orientation but without loss of generality FIG. 5A shows different camera positions (and orientations—not shown) in which the optical combiner has been removed from the line of sight (i.e., between calibration camera and calibration object). Alternatively, it is assumed that calibration camera **156** is pre-calibrated and its calibration parameters relating to aberrations (including distortions) are known. One possibility for storing and saving a representation of the calibration parameters is through a

camera calibration look-up table. Both calibration memory unit **154** (FIG. 4) and memory device **104** (FIG. 2) separately and individually are configured and operative to store the camera calibration look-up table of the calibration parameters. Alternatively, processor **102** (FIG. 2) is configured to run code that includes the calibration look-up table of the calibration parameters. In such an implementation the memory (e.g., memory device **104**, memory unit **154**) is embodied in the form of computer code (not shown). In such a look-up table, for example, one column may include a list of all the pixels of the calibration camera's sensor, and second and third columns may include data describing a shift (e.g., corresponding to the dimension of the pixels) in the x-direction and y-direction respectively, that is required to generate a distortion-free image from a raw image (produced by the sensor). In general, the shift is not necessarily an integer number of pixels, and this description is just one, specific and simplistic example of distortion correction parameterization. It is also typically assumed that the dimensions of calibration object **168** are large enough so that its angular size, as captured by calibration camera **156**, is at least as the dimensions of an image displayed on optical combiner **114** (currently removed in FIG. 5A). Alternatively, calibration camera **156** is distortion-free (i.e., not requiring the calibration look-up table).

(58) Calibration camera **156** is configured and operative to capture a plurality of calibration images **172.sub.1**, . . . , **172.sub.N** (where index N is a positive integer) of calibration object **168** from at least one position, and generally for N different positions denoted respectively as P(1), . . . , P(N) in HMD reference frame **122**. Specifically, calibration camera **156** captures a calibration image **172.sub.1** of object **168** at position (x.sub.1.sup.H,y.sub.1.sup.H,z.sub.1.sup.H), a calibration image **172.sub.2** of object **168** at position (x.sub.2.sup.H,y.sub.2.sup.H,z.sub.2.sup.H), and so forth to N, namely, a calibration image **172.sub.N** of object **168** at position (x.sub.N.sup.H,y.sub.N.sup.H,z.sub.N.sup.H). Camera multiple-axis actuator **158** is configured and operative to spatially move calibration camera **156** (e.g., via electric motors) to N positions P(1) through P(N), as diagrammatically illustrated in FIG. 5A. Calibration memory unit **154** is configured and operative to store calibration images **172.sub.1**, . . . , **172.sub.N**. The various positions from which calibration camera **156** acquires plurality of calibration images **172.sub.1**, . . . , **172.sub.N** represent various typical eye positions of eye **14** of a user wearing helmet **101**.

(59) For each calibration image **172.sub.1**, . . . , **172.sub.N** captured, there corresponds a respective camera aberration-free image **174.sub.1**, . . . , **174.sub.N** of calibration object **168** that is without camera optical aberration. Calibration object **168** acts as a standard, typically embodied in the form of a printed pattern of known design, geometry, dimensions, mathematical description, etc. Alternatively, calibration object **168** is embodied as a displayed (virtual) object (e.g., an image) on a display (not shown). Calibration memory unit **154** stores camera aberration-free images (or models) **174.sub.1**, . . . , **174.sub.N**. Hence, for each one of calibration images **172.sub.1**, . . . , **172.sub.N** acquired at different viewpoints (i.e., having specific position) of calibration camera **156** in HMD reference frame **122**, there is an associated and respective camera aberration-free image **174.sub.1**, . . . , **174.sub.N** corresponding to that viewpoint (i.e., a pair-wise association denoted according to identical index value). Calibration processor **152** is configured to make this pair-wise association. Specifically, for calibration image **172.sub.1**, acquired by calibration camera **156** at P(1), there exists a camera aberration-free image **174.sub.1**. Likewise for calibration image **172.sub.2** acquired at P(2) there exists a camera aberration-free image (or model thereof) **1742**, and so forth. More specifically, for each (i,j) pixel in each of calibration images **172.sub.1**, **172.sub.2**, . . . , **172.sub.N** there is associated with a corresponding (k,l) pixel in respective camera aberration-free images **174.sub.1**, **174.sub.2**, . . . , **174.sub.N**. In general, the aberration-free images are not generated simply by shifting by an integer number of pixels, but rather involve interpolation of neighboring pixels. Without unnecessarily complicating the description of the disclosed technique, it is assumed that the images are two-dimensional (2-D). Hence, pixel (i,j) in calibration image **172.sub.1**, denoted by **172.sub.1.sup.(i,j)** is associated with pixel (k,l) in camera aberration-free image **174.sub.1**, denoted by **174.sub.1.sup.(k,l)**, and so forth to N. The pair-wise association, as

well as the (i,j)-to-(k,l) pixel association forms part of camera aberration correction data **176** (reference data).

(60) Reference is now further made to FIG. 5B, which is a schematic diagram showing a second phase in the calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. The second phase in the initial calibration procedure determines a viewpoint-dependent optical see-through (OST) aberrations correction data **180**. Hence, the second phase involves the determination of correction data for rectifying OST aberrations for different positions (viewpoints) of calibration camera **156**. OST aberrations (including distortions) are mainly due to the interaction (e.g., refraction) between light from calibration object **168** (represented by chief rays **126.sub.1**, . . . , **126.sub.N** for P(1) to P(N), respectively) and partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**. These OST aberrations are essentially caused by optical aberrations of partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** (e.g., due to its spatial geometrical properties such as curvature (e.g., bringing about prismatic distortion effects), as well as optical characteristics such as refractive index, etc.).

(61) Calibration camera **156** is configured and operative to capture a plurality of calibration images **178.sub.1**, . . . , **178.sub.N** of calibration object **168**, through partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**. Calibration processor **152** and/or calibration memory unit **154** receive/s calibration images **178.sub.1**, . . . , **178.sub.N** from calibration camera **156**. For each calibration image **178.sub.1**, . . . , **178.sub.N**, calibration processor **152** is configured and operative to produce a respective camera aberration-free image (or model) **179.sub.1**, . . . , **179.sub.N** associated therewith. Hence, for each calibration image **178.sub.1**, . . . , **178.sub.N** there exists a respective (index-wise) camera aberration-free image **179.sub.1**, . . . , **179.sub.N**, for each of N positions and orientations of calibration camera **156**.

(62) As shown in FIG. 5B, calibration processor **152** (FIG. 4) receives calibration images **178.sub.1**, . . . , **178.sub.N**, and uses camera aberrations correction data **176** to produce OST distorted images **179.sub.1**, . . . , **179.sub.N**. Calibration processor **152** uses OST distorted images **179.sub.1**, . . . , **179.sub.N**, and camera aberration-free images **174.sub.1**, . . . , **174.sub.N** and is configured and operative to produce (e.g., estimate, compute) viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180** for each one of respective N positions of calibration camera **156** (as shown in the top-right block diagram of FIG. 5B). Calibration memory unit **154** is configured and operative to store viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180** therein. The term “correction” and derivative words thereof, used herein in the context of OST aberration correction data, refer to a process or method of substantially negating, reversing, or compensating (for) the effects of optical aberrations of partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**.

(63) Various methods may be utilized to compute viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180**, for example, by using feature (e.g., pixel) mapping (transformation) techniques, by performing an image-to-image comparison (according to index) of image properties of calibration images **179.sub.1**, . . . , **179.sub.N** with image respective image properties of OST aberration-free images **174.sub.1**, . . . , **174.sub.N**. Example properties used in the comparison may include spatial geometrical features, dimensions, relative orientation, and the like. Another example includes performing a point-by-point or pixel-wise comparison of an (i,j) pixel of calibration image **179.sub.1** with a corresponding (k,l) pixel of camera aberration-free image **174.sub.1**, and respectively so forth for each associated image pair up to N.

(64) Reference is now further made to FIG. 5C, which is a schematic diagram showing a third phase in the example calibration procedure of OST HMD system, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. Without loss of generality, the third phase calibration procedure describes a particular example involving a curved (e.g., spherical) optical combiner **114**, however, the principles of this calibration procedure apply to other display techniques such as waveguide projection techniques (not shown), and the like. The third phase in the calibration procedure involves determining viewpoint-dependent aberration correction data **188**

of electro-optical projection module **112** and optical combiner **114**, both corrected together (hereinafter interchangeably “viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberration correction data **188**”). In particular, electro-optical projection module **112** irradiates and projects light encoded with information, such as in the form of an image **184**, which in turn is partially reflected from partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** toward calibration camera **156**. Image **184** (or a plurality of images for that matter) may exhibit aberrations that are intrinsic to electro-optical projection module **112**, as well as aberrations that are extrinsic, arising for example, from an off-axis position of electro-optical projection module **112**. In addition, the reflection of image **184** off a curved projection surface of partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** will also exhibit aberrations to its appearance when acquired by calibration camera **156**.

(65) In accordance with the third phase in the calibration procedure, the aforementioned effects are countered. In particular, calibration processor **152** transmits a calibration image **182** to electro-optical projection module **112**, which in turn irradiates and projects it onto partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** as image **184**. Calibration camera **156** is configured and operative to acquire images from a plurality of N camera viewpoints (i.e., $P(1), \dots, P(N)$), and to respectively output reflected calibration image **186.sub.1** (captured from $P(1)$), reflected calibration image **1862** (captured from $P(2)$)—not shown), and so forth up to reflected calibration image **186.sub.N** (captured from $P(N)$). Calibration processor **152** receives reflected calibration images **186.sub.1**, $\dots$, **186.sub.N** from calibration camera **156** and/or via calibration memory unit **154**. Calibration processor **152** is configured and operative to produce viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module aberration correction data **188**, given calibration image **182**, and reflected calibration images **186.sub.1**, $\dots$, **186.sub.N**, and camera aberrations correction data **176**, by employing various techniques. Example techniques include methods of image transformation on a feature or pixel-wise basis (image warping) for spatial (geometric) aberration compensation (correction). According to one image transformation method, calibration processor **152** determines N different transformations for N respective viewpoints of calibration camera **156**. Each transformation defines how pixels or groups of pixels in a reflected calibration image are mapped to respective location-similar pixels or groups of pixels of calibration image **182**, taking into account camera aberration correction data **176** (FIGS. 5A and 5B) of calibration camera **156**. Hence, viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module aberration correction data **188** enables the transformation of reflected calibration images **186.sub.1**, $\dots$, **186.sub.N** acquired from N viewpoints to be corrected before they are projected so as to take into account aberrations of electro-optical projection module **112** to yield electro-optical projection module aberration-free images when viewed from various eye positions.

(66) As will be hereinafter described in greater detail, replacing calibration camera **156** with eye **14** of user **10** wearing helmet **101** (post-calibration), and subsequently determining eye **14** position via eye position determination module **108** (FIG. 2) enables to associate eye **14** position with one of $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. Processor **102** (FIG. 2) receives eyeball feature position data generated from eye position determination module **108** and associates viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module aberration correction data **188** corresponding to one of the viewpoints $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. Generally, (and in case) a determined eye position does not precisely correspond with one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$, processor **102** is configured and operative to derive appropriate correction data corresponding to that eye position by interpolating from correction data associated with at least one closest matching position (i.e., one of $P(1), \dots, P(N)$). Processor **102** is configured to derive from the correction data, closest-matching correction data that is associated with at least one closest matching position. The eyeball feature position data may have a higher resolution than the resolution of the predetermined information (e.g., calibration data) (e.g., millimeter resolution versus sub-millimeter resolution). Alternatively, the eyeball feature position data is truncated (i.e., approximated, rounded) by eye position determination module **108**. For

example, when a determined eye position falls exactly in between two positions P(i) and P(j), processor **102** may generate the correction data by averaging the correction data associated with P(i) and P(j). Thereafter, processor **102** directs electro-optical projection module **112** to irradiate and project image **184** that is pre-distorted or compensated according to one of the corresponding viewpoints, such that when it is reflected off partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114** it appears or perceived to be substantially aberration-free (i.e., although the projected image is itself distorted as well as the real-world view as seen through partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**).

(67) The fourth phase in the calibration procedure involves the construction of unified correction data as a function of N different positions of calibration camera, according to the preceding phases (i.e., first, second and third) of the calibration procedure. Reference is now further made to FIGS. **6A**, **6B**, **6C**, **6D**, and **6E**, which demonstrate how data attained from preceding calibration steps are compounded to arrive at unified correction data that may be represented in the form of a lookup table. FIGS. **6A-6E** show the fourth phase in the calibration procedure.

(68) Specifically, FIG. **6A** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of not correcting the eye position of a user, and OST aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. FIG. **6B** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting the eye position of a user, but not correcting for OST aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. FIG. **6C** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting for eye position of a user, and OST aberration correction, but not of correcting for electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. FIG. **6D** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting for the eye position of a user, OST aberration correction, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. FIG. **6E** is a schematic block diagram illustrating a representation of the unified correction data in the form of a lookup table.

(69) FIG. **6A** shows electro-optical projection module **112** and optical combiner **114**, an (externally viewed) object **192**, two rays **194** and **196**, and two positions: P (i.e., the actual position of the user's eye), and DEP (design eye position) (i.e., a default assumed eye position in an HMD without an eye position determination capability). Electro-optical projection module **112** projects image **184** onto optical combiner **114** that includes a single object, namely, a rectangle supposed being in alignment with object **192** as seen through the HMD (i.e., the aim is for a rectangle **200** to appear to the user symmetrically enclosing object **192** (i.e., object **192** is at the center of rectangle **200**). For example, in pilot applications, such alignment may be used to emphasize a target for a pilot). Rectangle **200** is a simplified representation of what the user may see when looking through optical combiner **114**. Rectangle **200** includes an object denoted by dot **204** and a virtual rectangle denoted by **202**. In a situation where the actual position P of the eye is unknown, and without viewpoint dependent OST aberrations correction and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations correction, virtual rectangle **202** appears to the user above a perceived position **198** of object **192** as seen through optical combiner **114** (represented by dot **204**). Specifically, light ray **194** represents an exemplary light path from the DEP to object **192**, and light ray **196** represents an exemplary light path from a position P passing through optical combiner **114** that is astray. For the sake of simplicity of explaining the disclosed technique, the intersection of light rays **194** and **196** denoted by **190** is at optical combiner **114** and it is where image **200** of virtual rectangle **202** appears to user. Note that operationally image **200** is not focused at optical combiner **114** but further away, although the principles of the disclosed technique apply likewise for different focus distances. Dot **204** represents perceived position **198** of object **192** to the user looking through optical combiner **114** due to see-through distortions, although the real position of object **192** is displaced from perceived position **198**.

(70) Reference is now made to FIG. **6B**, which shows the same hardware features as in FIG. **6A** apart from the inclusion of eye position determination module **108**. FIG. **6B** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting the eye position of a user, but not correction for OST

aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. Electro-optical projection module **112** projects image **205** onto optical combiner **114**. Eye position determination module **108** determines an eye position at point P. A light ray **210** represents an exemplary light path from determined user eye position P through optical combiner **114** to object **192**. The user, however, perceives the position of object **192** at a position denoted by dot **198**. FIG. **6B** shows the effect of correcting the eye position of the user, but not the correction of OST aberrations, and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations. With only corrections to the eye position of the user, virtual rectangle **216** in the FOV **200** seen by the user below a perceived position **198** of object **192** (as denoted by dot **204**).

(71) Reference is now made to FIG. **6C**, which shows the same hardware features as in FIG. **6B**. FIG. **6C** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting the eye position of a user and correcting for OST aberrations (see-through distortions), but not correcting for electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations (display distortions). Electro-optical projection module **112** projects image **206** onto optical combiner **114**. Eye position determination module **108** determines an eye position at point P. A light ray **230** represents an exemplary light path from determined user eye position P through optical combiner **114** to a perceived position **198** of object **192**, as it appears to a user through optical combiner **114**. With corrections to the eye position and corrections of OST aberrations, but without the display correction, a virtual rectangle **238** in FOV **200** as seen by the user appears slightly below its desired position around the perceived position **198** of object **192** (as denoted by dot **204**).

(72) Reference is now to FIG. **6D**, which shows the same hardware features as in FIG. **6C**. FIG. **6D** is a schematic illustration showing the effect of correcting for the eye position of a user, OST aberration correction (see-through corrections), and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations (display corrections). Electro-optical projection module **112** projects image **207** onto optical combiner **114**. Eye position determination module **108** determines an eye position at point P. A light ray **242** represents an exemplary light path from determined user eye position P through optical combiner **114** to a perceived position **198** of object **192**, as it appears to a user through optical combiner **114**. With the combined corrections to the position of the eye of the user, see-through corrections of optical combiner **114**, as well as display corrections, a virtual rectangle **250** is properly superimposed with a perceived position **198** of object **192** (as denoted by dot **204** located centrally with respect to virtual rectangle **250**). As indicated above, with regard to the basic configuration, eye position determination module **108** is not part of OST HMD system and the corresponding calibration phase shown in FIGS. **6A-6D** may be implemented by receiving eyeball feature position data generated by any of the methods detailed in the basic configuration.

(73) FIG. **6E** illustrates an example representation of a unified correction data (database) having the form of a lookup table **370**. Lookup table **370** tabulates the position-dependent corrections $C_{sup.2}, C_{sup.3}, C_{sup.U}$ for each one of N positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. Correction $C_{sup.2}$ in the calibration procedure represents the second phase correction, i.e., viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180** (FIG. **5B**). Correction $C_{sup.3}$ in the calibration procedure represents the third phase, i.e., viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberration correction data **188** (FIG. **5C**). Ultimately, the respective corrections $C_{sup.2}$, and $C_{sup.3}$ in the calibration procedure in lead to unified correction data CL. In general, the disclosed technique is compatible with various types of calibration procedures so long that the end result is unified correction data $C_{sup.U}(N)$ for each of N positions, as may be represented by lookup table **370**.

(74) Generally, for each one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$ there corresponds respective (index-wise) position-dependent unified correction data $C_{sup.U}(1), \dots, C_{sup.U}(N)$. Specifically, for position $P(1)$ there corresponds a position-dependent unified correction data $C_{sup.U}(1)$, as well as corrections $C_{sup.2}(1), C_{sup.3}(1)$; for position $P(2)$ there corresponding a position-dependent unified correction data $C_{sup.U}(2)$, as well as corrections $C_{sup.2}(2), C_{sup.3}(2)$, and so forth to N.

The unified corrections (denoted by the “U” superscript) represent compounded corrections taken into account at each individual step, for each N different eye positions. Specifically, C.sup.U(1) represents the unified correction corresponding to eye position 1, C.sup.U(2) represents the unified correction corresponding to eye position 2, and so forth to C.sup.U(N) for eye position N. The unified corrections may depend on the parameterization used. In effect, and for example, without any correction an image of a symbol is intended for being displayed at a symbol location (x, y), but instead, a first correction corrects the intended symbol location to (x.sub.1,y.sub.1), the second correction further corrects the symbol location to (x.sub.2,x.sub.2), such that the corrections are compounded to attain the unified correction for a symbol location (x.sub.u,y.sub.u), so that the image of the symbol appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to an outwardly viewed object (e.g., a real object, a virtual object (image), a completely hidden object, a partially hidden object).

(75) Reference is now made to FIG. 7, which is a schematic block diagram of a method, generally referenced **450**, illustrating steps in the initial calibration procedure, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. Method **450** initiates with procedure **452**. In procedure **452**, a calibration object is provided, and an optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system and a calibration camera that is pre-calibrated, are mounted on at least one platform, such that the calibration camera is in a direct line-of-sight (LOS) to calibration object, without an optical combiner being interposed between calibration camera and calibration object. With reference to FIGS. 2, 3, 4, 5A, and 7, OST HMD system **100** (FIG. 5A), calibration camera **156** (FIGS. 4 and 5A), and calibration object **168** (FIGS. 4 and 5A) are mounted on platforms **1701** (OST HMD system **100** and calibration camera **156**) and **1702** (calibration object **168**), such that calibration camera **156** is in a direct LOS to calibration object **168**, without optical combiner (FIGS. 2 and 3) being interposed between calibration camera **156** and calibration object **168**.

(76) In procedure **454**, viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data pertaining to the optical combiner, as a function of N different positions of calibration camera with respect to a position and orientation of calibration object is determined. The optical combiner is interposed between the calibration camera and the calibration object. With reference to FIGS. 4, 5A and 5B, calibration processor **152** (FIG. 4) determines viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180** (FIG. 5B) taking into account camera aberration correction data **176** (FIG. 5A), for N different positions, P(1), . . . , P(N), of calibration camera **156** (FIGS. 4 and 5B) with respect to a position and orientation of calibration object **168** (FIGS. 4 and 5B). Optical combiner **114** is interposed between (FIG. 5B) calibration camera **156** and calibration object **168**.

(77) In procedure **456**, viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module and optical combiner correction data is determined, as a function of N different positions of the calibration camera is determined. With reference to FIGS. 4 and 5C, calibration processor **152** (FIG. 4) determines viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberration correction data **188** (FIG. 5C) pertaining to electro-optical projection module **112** (FIG. 5C). Electro-optical projection module **112** projects calibration image **182** (FIG. 5C) toward optical combiner **114** (FIG. 5C), which in turn, reflects reflected calibration image **184** (FIG. 5C) toward calibration camera **156**. Calibration camera **156** captures a plurality of N calibration images **186.sub.1**, . . . , **186.sub.N** (FIG. 5C) of reflected calibration image **184**, from N respective positions P(1), . . . , P(N).

(78) In procedure **458**, unified correction data as a function of N different positions of calibration camera is constructed, according to the camera aberration correction data, the viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data, and the viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection module and optical combiner correction data. With reference to FIGS. 4, 5A, 5B, 5C, and 6A-6E, calibration processor **152** (FIG. 4) constructs unified correction data **370** (FIG. 6E) as a function of N different positions P(1), . . . , P(N) (FIGS. 5A-5C, 6A-6E) of calibration camera **156**, according

to viewpoint-dependent OST aberrations correction data **180** (FIG. 5B), and viewpoint-dependent electro-optical projection model aberration and optical combiner correction data **188** (FIGS. 5C, 6C). Unified correction data **370** (FIG. 6E) may be represented as a lookup table. Lookup table **370** represents a database of correction information that associates N correction data (or models) for each position P(1), . . . , P(N) in HMD reference frame **122**.

(79) Following the initial calibration procedure, OST HMD system **100** is ready for mounting onto head **12** of user **10** as shown in FIG. 3. The calibration data produced in the initial calibration procedure or at least a derivative thereof, including lookup table **370** is transferred to memory device **104** of OST HMD system **100** for retrieval. Once user **10** mounts OST HMD system **100** via HMD-to-head coupler **101** (e.g., in the form of helmet), calibration camera **152** is effectively replaced with eye **14** (FIG. 3) of user **10**. Eye **14** of different users may assume a plurality of different eye positions (i.e., given different users having different relative eye-to-head positions, as well as different relative HMD-to-head positions). Eye position determination module **108** (FIGS. 2 and 3) is configured and operative to determine position data associated with a position of eye **14** with respect to OST HMD system reference frame **122**. This position data may be partial (i.e., including only part of the position coordinates (e.g., x and y coordinate values, but not the z coordinate value in a Cartesian coordinate system)).

(80) To further elucidate the configuration, operation, and implementation OST HMD system **100**, reference is now further made to FIGS. 8A, 8B, 8C, and 8D. FIG. 8A is a schematic diagram showing various parts of an eye of a user, referred in the context of the disclosed technique. FIG. 8B is a schematic diagram showing an acquired image of the eye shown in FIG. 8A, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 8C is a schematic illustration showing the use of unified correction data for providing real-time alignment between a projected virtual object on optical combiner and a real-world object as viewed by an eye of a user, constructed and operative in accordance with the embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 8D is a schematic illustration showing orientation correction of a projected image with respect to a rotated orientation of OST HMD. FIG. 8A illustrates various typical examples of eyeball features of eye **14** of user **10** (FIG. 3), including for example, pupil **14.sub.1**, iris **14.sub.2**, sclera **14.sub.3**, conjunctiva **14.sub.4**, blood vessel **14.sub.5**, inside corner **14.sub.6**, outside corner **14.sub.7**, eye opening boundary **14.sub.8**, and the like. Eye position determination module **108** (FIG. 3) determines position data associated with at least one position of at least one eyeball feature (e.g., **14.sub.1**, **14.sub.2**, **14.sub.3**, **14.sub.4**, **14.sub.5**, **14.sub.6**, **14.sub.7**, etc.) of eye **14** of user **10** with respect to HMD reference frame **122**, by various techniques. Eyeball feature detection techniques (i.e., used for determining eye position) are employed by the disclosed technique (e.g., video or still image oculo-graphy), typically involve capturing at least one image **500** (FIG. 8B) of eye **14** (i.e., or at least part thereof) via an image capture device (e.g., a camera) and deriving from the captured image eyeball feature positions that are correlated with HMD reference frame **122**. An infrared (IR) light emitting diode (LED) may be used to illuminate eye **14**. Eye position determination module **108** determines the position data associated with the position of eye **14** in HMD reference frame **122** according to the following steps. Eye position determination module **108** acquires (i.e., via a camera—not shown) an image **500** (FIG. 8B) of eye **14** (FIG. 8A), such that image **500** includes at least one (typically a plurality of) imaged eyeball feature(s), such as an image of pupil **500.sub.1**, and image of iris **500.sub.2**, image of sclera **500.sub.3**, image of blood vessel **500.sub.5**, image of inside corner **500.sub.6**, image of outside corner **500.sub.7**, image of eye opening boundary **500.sub.8**, and the like.

(81) Eye position determination module **108** defines a transformation (i.e., a mapping) between an image coordinate system **502** (FIG. 8B) and HMD reference frame **122** (coordinate system) so to construct a transformation (i.e., with respect to position) between eyeball features in HMD reference frame **122** and corresponding imaged eyeball features present in image **500**. At least one imaged eyeball feature present in image **500** within image coordinate system **502** is associated with

a respective real eyeball feature in HMD reference frame **122**. It is noted that eye position determination module **108** may include more than one camera (not shown) for determining the eye position, so as to obtain an accurate 3-D eye position data (including depth). Alternatively, eye position determination module **108** employs other techniques, for example light beam (e.g., laser) scanning and sensing methods (not shown) to determine the eye position. When using a single camera, 2-D eye position is straightforwardly acquired from image **500**, while a third dimension (i.e., depth in 3-D eye position data) may be also determined by various techniques, such as by knowing the size of eye **14**, or eye ball features (e.g., pupil **14.sub.1**) based on known user-specific sizes. Alternatively or in addition, 3-D eye position data is determined via IR oculography as mentioned hereinabove. Particularly in this method (also denoted as the corneal specular reflection approach), at least one infrared (IR) light emitting diode (LED) (not shown) emits IR light that at least partially illuminates eye **14**, an IR light sensor (not shown) detects the reflection or glint **14.sub.9** (FIG. **8A**), and processor **102** (FIG. **2**) determines the glint size so as to assess 3-D eye position. Alternatively, in special cases the need to determine the exact eye position is skipped, and instead processor **102** guesses an eye position and relates the guessed eye position (or a guestimate position) with corresponding correction data. Further alternatively, instead of determining 3-D eye position, only 2-D eye position data is determined without greatly degrading accuracy.

(82) With reference to FIG. **8C**, eye position determination module **108** is configured and operative to determine the position of eye **14** with respect to OST HMD system reference frame **122**.

Processor **102** may facilitate in the eye position determination. Preferably, the determined position of eye **14** may correspond with one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. The value of N as well as the density of positions within a given volume in space of HMD system reference frame **122** is related to the accuracy or resolution that is required. Generally, the greater the value of N and the greater the density of points or positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$, the greater the chance of an arbitrary user's eye position to match one of $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. Eye position determination module **108** is configured and operative to first determine position of eye **14** with respect to OST HMD system reference frame **122**, and second to associate the determined position with one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$. In case the eye position data associated with the eye position does not precisely match (i.e., within predetermined tolerances) one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$, eye position determination module **108** is configured to associate the determined eye position with the closest match (i.e., one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$). Either one of processor **102** and eye position determination module **108** is configured to select one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$ in a situation where there is more than one closest matching position (e.g., two closest matching position values). Alternatively, as aforementioned, in case a determined eye position does not precisely correspond with one of positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$, processor **102** is configured and operative to derive appropriate correction data corresponding to that eye position by use of interpolation.

(83) Once eye position determination module **108** determines eye **14** position, e.g., $P(j)$, it provides (e.g., transmits) the result to processor **102**, which in turn retrieves from memory device **104** (i.e., lookup table **370** stored therein, FIG. **6E**) unified correction data, $C_{sup.U(n)}$ associated with the n -th determined position $P(n)$, where n is an integer: $0 < n \leq N$. Based on the unified correction data, processor **102** is configured to generate an image **550** (i.e., in the form of data ("image data"), this image is pre-distorted) and to provide this image to electro-optical display module **112**, which in turn is configured and operative to irradiate and project the image onto optical combiner **114** (represented as partially reflected image **184** in FIG. **8C**). Projected and partially reflected image **184** appears to eye **14** of user **10** to be superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to object **552** (similar to object **168** (FIG. **3**), located externally to OST HMD and appearing in the LOS **554** of user), as exemplified by (perceived) image **556**. Hence, in real-time, processor **102** uses the position of eye **14** in the HMD reference frame **122** (i.e., helmet coordinate system), and the exact position and orientation (P&O) of the OST HMD or helmet relative to object **552**, to determine (via eye position determination module **108**) the position of user's eye **14** relative to object **552**.

Processor **102** takes this P&O into consideration for generating image **550** such that virtual object(s) in image **550** appear(s) overlaid in an aligned manner with respect to (real) object **552** when viewed from the currently determined eye position.

(84) Processor **102** is configured and operative to associate and register a current determined eye position outputted by eye position determination module **108** with a one of the N different positions $P(1), \dots, P(N)$ that were registered by calibration camera **152**. For example, this association and registration may be performed in accordance with the closest match (e.g., via error minimization techniques). Processor **102** applies the appropriate correction model to image **146** (FIG. 3) or image **550** (FIG. 8C) according to the current detected position of eye **14**, such that reflected image **144** (FIG. 3) or image **184** (FIG. 8C) appears in an aligned position and orientation with respect to external object **140** located outwardly to the user through optical combiner **114**, as representatively illustrated in FIG. 3 by a superimposed image **148** and in FIG. 8C by superimposed (perceived) image **556**.

(85) With reference to FIG. 8D, tracking system **106** (FIG. 2), processor **102**, and electro-optical projection module **112** are further configured and operative to correct the orientation of a projected image when head **12** of user and thereby OST HMD system **100** (and/or helmet **101**) rotates with respect to an orientation of an externally viewed object. FIG. 8D shows a particular example of a typical field-of-view (FOV) of OST HMD **100** being at a reference orientation, denoted by **570** (dotted line). The example shown in FIG. 8D is representative of a limited case having one degree-of-freedom (DOF) in which the user's head **12** rotates about a center axis, and the object visualized is positioned exactly at this center axis. When user's head **12** rotates (i.e., rolls around the center axis), the current OST HMD FOV **572** rotates correspondingly (arrow) with respect to the reference (noncurrent) OST HMD FOV **570**. Tracking system **106** is configured to detect changes in the orientation of OST HMD **100** (or head **12**) with respect to previous orientations, and also with respect to external (real or virtual) object (e.g., horizon). Tracking system **106** outputs data indicative of these changes and provides this data to processor **102**, which in turn is configured to direct electro-optical projection module **112** to project an orientation-corrected image **576** onto optical combiner **114**, such that orientation of orientation-corrected image **576** matches the reference orientation (i.e., reference OST HMD FOV **570**). Without correction, the projected image would be rotated along with the rotation of OST HMD FOV **572**, as shown by orientation-uncorrected image **574** (dotted line). For the sake of simplicity, the example shown in FIG. 8D only shows a particular 1-DOF case, as for a more general 6-DOF case, HMD azimuth, elevation, and position are also taken into consideration.

(86) Eye position determination module **108** may optionally be further configured and operative to estimate a gaze vector **504** (FIG. 8B) of eye **14** that defines an estimated looking direction or orientation of eye **14** by image processing methods and algorithms, such as those employing contour detection (e.g., of pupil **14.sub.1** relative to iris **14.sub.2** and relative to eye opening boundary **14.sub.8**, or between other eye feature combinations), via the pupil-center-corneal reflection (PCCR) method, and the like. For a precise estimate of gaze vector **504** a calibration procedure may be typically required. The disclosed technique does not necessitate determination of gaze vector **504**, as typically, an average position of eye may be sufficient. A typical example situation where only the average eye position is sufficient may be when head **12** of user **10** turns so that the target (e.g., object **140**) is seen more or less along a center axis of the optical combiner **114** that is illuminated with a displayed image.

(87) Reference is now made to FIG. 9, which is a schematic block diagram illustrating the steps of a method, generally referenced **600**, constructed and operative in accordance with the disclosed technique. Method **600** initiates with procedure **602**. In procedure **602**, predetermined information is provided that relates correction data of an OST HMD with a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position of at least one eye of a user viewing an object having at least one of a known position, and a known orientation with respect to a first

reference frame. With reference to FIGS. 3, 4, 5A-5C, and 6A-6E which relate to a calibration method that includes four phases implemented by an OST HMD calibration system **150** (FIG. 4), for generating unified correction data **370** (FIG. 6E) in the form of lookup table. Unified correction data **370** includes different respective position data values $P(1), \dots, P(N)$ of at least one eyeball feature (FIG. 8A) position of at least one eye **14** (FIG. 3) of user **10** viewing at least one object **140** (FIG. 3) or object **191** (FIG. 6C) having at least one of a known position $(x_{\text{sub.1.sup.O}}, y_{\text{sub.1.sup.O}}, z_{\text{sub.1.sup.O}})$ and a known orientation $(\beta_{\alpha.\text{sub.1.sup.O}}, \beta_{\text{sub.1.sup.O}}, \gamma_{\text{sub.1.sup.O}})$ with respect to a first reference frame **142**.

(88) In procedure **604**, at least one eyeball feature position with respect to a second reference frame is determined, so as to generate corresponding eyeball feature position data. With reference to FIGS. 2, 3, 8A, 8B, eye position determination module **108** (FIGS. 2 and 3) determines at least one eyeball feature (FIG. 8A) position (FIG. 8B), so as to generate corresponding eyeball feature position data $P(1), \dots, P(N)$.

(89) In procedure **606**, at least one of a position, and position and orientation of the second reference frame is determined with respect to the first reference frame. With reference to FIGS. 2 and 3, tracking system **106** (FIG. 2) and processor **102** determine at least one of a position, and position and orientation of the second reference frame **140** (FIG. 3) with respect to the first reference frame **122** (FIG. 3).

(90) In procedure **608**, an image for viewing by the user is generated and irradiated, such that the image appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to the object that is either one of at least partially appearing outwardly and completely hidden to the user, according to the predetermined information, the eyeball feature position data, and the at least one of the orientation, and position and orientation. With reference to FIGS. 2, 3, 6D, 6E, and 8C, processor **102** (FIG. 2) generates image **146** (FIG. 3) or image **550** (FIG. 8C) that electro-optical projection module **112** (FIG. 3) irradiates and projects onto optical combiner **114** (FIGS. 3, 8C), such that the projected image appears to eye **14** (FIGS. 3, 8C) of user **10** superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to object **140** (FIG. 3) or object **552** (FIG. 8C) appearing outwardly to the user, according to the predetermined information (unified correction data (lookup table **370**, FIG. 6E), eyeball feature position data $P(1), \dots, P(N)$, as well as according to the relative P&O between the HMD and the object).

(91) In accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique, electro-optical projection module **112** and eye position determination module **108** are embodied as a single integrated device. To further elucidate the particulars of this embodiment, reference is made to FIGS. 10A, 10B, and 10C. FIG. 10A is a schematic illustration of a partial block diagram of an OST HMD system, generally referenced **700**, showing an integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module, constructed and operative in accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. 10B is a schematic illustration of an example implementation of the integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module of FIG. 10A in greater detail. FIG. 10C is a schematic illustration showing a high-level configuration and operation aspects of the OST HMD system of FIG. 10A.

(92) OST HMD system **700** is identical to OST HMD system **100** (FIG. 2) apart from electro-optical display module **110** (of FIG. 2). In particular, OST HMD system **700** includes optical combiner **114** and an integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704**. Integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** integrates (the functionality and operation) of electro-optical display module **110** and eye position determination module **108** into a single unit (partly for the purposes of saving space, weight, complexity, and the like). FIG. 10A shows a partial inventory of OST HMD system **700** containing only the relevant differential modifications with respect to OST HMD system **100** (FIG. 2).

(93) FIG. 10B shows an example implementation of the structure and configuration of integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** in greater detail. In such an

integrated device there is a plurality of discrete light detection elements and a plurality of light emission elements. The light detection elements are configured and operative as light detection elements **708** such as camera photodiodes (represented by as shaded areas in FIG. **10B**). The light emission elements are configured and operative as light emission elements **706** (pixels) (represented by non-shaded areas in FIG. **10B**). The combined configuration and operation of the camera photodiodes **708** constitute an image sensor that act as a camera enabling to determine eye position of the user (similarly as eye position determination module **108**). The combined configuration and operation of the display photodiodes **706** or pixels constitute an electro-optical display configured and operative to irradiate an image for viewing by at least one eye of the user. Integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** is capable of acquiring images as well as displaying images synchronized alternately. An example implementation of such an integrated device is a bi-directional organic light emitting diode (OLED) micro display made by the Fraunhofer Institute (specifically, the Fraunhofer Center for Organics, Materials, and Electronic Devices Dresden (COMEDD)). This aspect of the disclosed technique may be implemented by a plurality of integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination modules **304** (not shown) (e.g., to more accurately determine eye position). In one implementation (not shown), there are a plurality of integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination modules **304** for one eye. In another implementation (not shown), there is integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **304** for every eye.

(94) Integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** is configured and operative to determine at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14** of user **10** wearing OST HMD **700** (diagrammatically represented by light ray **710**), to generate corresponding eyeball feature position data, and provide (e.g., transmit) the eyeball feature position data to processor **102** (FIG. **2**). Simultaneously, integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** is configured and operative to irradiate and project light encoded with information (e.g., an image **714**, whose light rays are diagrammatically represented by FIG. **10C** by light rays **712** impinging and at least partially reflecting from partially reflective partially transmissive optical element **114**) for viewing by at least one eye **14** of user **10** wearing OST HMD system **700**. Processor **102** (FIG. **2**) provides an image **716** that has been pre-distorted to integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704**, based on unified correction data **370** (FIG. **6E**), in accordance with the principles of the disclosed technique heretofore described. The use of integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** may be advantageous in enabling the capture of images of the eye from its gazing direction (i.e., which is advantageous in itself for registering the various eye features, as there are substantially no obscurations as in the case where the camera is oriented toward the side of the eye, but the eye is gazing exactly toward the camera). Hence, the determination of at least one eyeball feature position and the generation and irradiation of the images is performed along a common optical axis.

(95) In addition, integrated electro-optical projection and eye position determination module **704** reduces occupied volume, weight and power consumption of the device in comparison with the use of disjoint units, electro-optical projection module **112**, and eye position determination module **108** (FIG. **2**).

(96) In accordance with a further embodiment of the disclosed technique, the electro-optical projection module and eye position determination module are configured and operative to have an on-axis optical arrangement. To further elaborate the particulars of this embodiment, reference is now made to FIGS. **11A** and **11B**. FIG. **11A** is a schematic illustration showing another optical configuration of electro-optical projection module and eye position determination module, constructed and operative in accordance with a further embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. **11B** is a schematic illustration showing the optical configuration of FIG. **11A** in greater detail.

(97) FIG. **11A** shows OST HMD **730** is substantially similar to OST HMD **100** (FIG. **3**), in construction and operation, apart from optical configuration **750** of electro-optical projection

module **112** and eye position determination module **108**. OST HMD **730** includes an electro-optical projection module **732** (i.e., substantially similar to electro-optical projection module **112** of FIGS. **2** and **3**), an eye position determination module **734** (i.e., substantially similar to eye position determination module **108** of FIGS. **2** and **3**), and an optical fold **736**. Optical fold **736** may be embodied in the form of a prism, a partially transmissive partially reflective mirror, etc. Optical configuration **750** (FIG. **11B**) illustrates an on-axis optical arrangement of electro-optical projection module **732** and eye position determination module **734**. Electro-optical projection module **732** is configured and operative to project an image **740** onto optical combiner **114**, as diagrammatically represented by light rays **742**. Eye position determination module **734** is configured and operative to determine at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14** of user **10**, by at least one of active techniques (e.g., reflection of projected IR or visible light and detection via at least one camera) and passive techniques (e.g., via detection of at least one camera), as diagrammatically represented by light rays **744**. Optical fold **736** is configured and operative to transmit there-through light beams from electro-optical projection module **732** (i.e., light rays **742** toward optical combiner **114**), and concurrently reflect externally incoming light beams (i.e., light rays **744**) from optical combiner **114** toward eye position determination module **734**.

(98) In accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique, there is provided a configuration incorporating multiple eye position determination modules arranged at different spatial positions with respect to the OST HMD (where the determination of at least one eyeball feature position is performed separately from at least two different spatial positions). To further elaborate the particulars of this embodiment, reference is now made to FIGS. **12A** and **12B**. FIG. **12A** is a schematic illustration showing a side-view arrangement, of OST HMD, generally referenced **770**, having multiple eye position determination modules, constructed and operative in accordance with another embodiment of the disclosed technique. FIG. **12B** is a schematic illustration showing a partial forward facing view of OST HMD of FIG. **12A**.

(99) FIG. **12A** illustrates an OST HMD configuration **770** that includes a plurality of eye position determination modules **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2**, each of which is operative to determine at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14** of user **10**. This embodiment of the disclosed technique is substantially similar to the embodiment described in conjunction with FIG. **3**, apart from the employment of multiple eye position determination modules **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2**. Although only two eye position determination modules **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2** are shown in FIGS. **12A** and **12B**, for the sake of simplicity, there can be an arbitrary number thereof, whose configuration and operating principles likewise apply thereto. Analogously, for each eye (**14.sub.L** or **14.sub.R**—FIG. **12B**) there can be assigned at least one eye position determination module for detecting at least one eyeball feature position for the respective eye. This implementation is useful in the case where there is a display module provided for each eye, and each display module is associated separately and respectively with a reference frame (e.g. an HMD having a particular degree of freedom accounting for a change to the interpupillary distance (IPD)). In accordance with the current embodiment, each eye position determination module **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2** is coupled (not shown) with processor **102** (FIG. **2**). Multiple eye position determination modules are used to enhance the accuracy of eye position determination (e.g., better discernment of depth or other coordinate(s)). Each eye position determination module **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2** may use passive and/or active detection techniques, as noted hereinabove. Light rays **1301** and **1302** represent exemplary and respective light paths traversed in the eye position detection of eye position detection modules **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2**. The multiple eye position determination modules may be of the same type (e.g., camera-based techniques having at least one light illumination source). Alternatively, the multiple eye position determination modules are of different types. For example, two eye position determination modules, where one is camera-based, the other is laser scanning (and sensing) based.

(100) Alternatively, eye position determination modules **108.sub.1** and **108.sub.2** are coupled with

each other in a cascaded configuration (not shown), such that the determination of eye position outputted by one eye position determination module is used to refine or augment the output of the other eye position determination module, so as to produce an enhanced eye determination output. In such a configuration only one eye position determination module (or not all) may be coupled with processor **102** (not shown).

(101) According to the disclosed technique, the image that is projected to the user appears to the user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to an externally viewed object. The object can be either completely viewable to the user (e.g., unobstructed, exposed, bare, visible, etc.), completely hidden to the user (e.g., totally obstructed, concealed, invisible, etc.), or at least partially hidden and partially viewable (e.g., only partially appearing outwardly that is partly visible and partly invisible). The object may be a physical object (e.g., composed of at least one material), a synthetic or virtual object (e.g., a computer-generated and projected image), etc. To further demonstrate an example implementation of the system and method of the disclosed technique in a case of a hidden object, reference is now made to FIGS. **13A** and **13B**. FIG. **13A** is a schematic illustration of an example implementation of the disclosed technique in a surgery setting, generally referenced **800**, targeting a hidden object that is an internal body part of a subject. FIG. **13B** is a schematic illustration of the surgery setting of FIG. **13A**, showing a projected image of the hidden internal body part of the subject being superimposed in an aligned manner with a corresponding position of the hidden internal body part of the subject.

(102) FIGS. **13A** and **13B** show a subject **802** (e.g., a patient) in a surgery setting targeted for a medical procedure of an internal body part (i.e., an object) (e.g., vertebrae in this example) **804** that is hidden from view to a user (e.g., a surgeon, a medical practitioner, etc.) of the system and method of the disclosed technique. For example, internal body part **804** is targeted for the medical procedure (e.g., surgery). Further shown in FIG. **13B** is tracking system **106** including two distinct units **106.sub.1** and **106.sub.2**. First unit **106.sub.1** of the tracking system is mounted on HMD OST **100** (FIG. **3**) and is associated with optical assembly reference frame **122**. Second unit **106.sub.2** of the tracking system, associated with object reference frame **142**, is rigidly coupled with subject **802** (e.g., to part of a skeleton or bone) such that the position and orientation of second unit **106.sub.2** is known with respect to the position and orientation of hidden object **804** (e.g., via medical imaging techniques, such as computed tomography (CT) scan, magnetic resonance imaging (MRI), etc.). Tracking system **106** enables registration between the real-world view as seen by the user and a projected image augmenting the real-world view.

(103) FIG. **13B** illustrates an eye **14** of the user viewing subject **802** through optical combiner **114**. Eye position determination module **108** is configured to determine at least one eyeball feature position of eye **14**, according to the embodiments heretofore described. Electro-optical projection module **112**, which is associated with second reference frame **122**, is configured to irradiate and project an image **808** provided by processor **102** (FIG. **2**) for viewing by the user wearing OST HMD **100** (FIG. **1**). As noted hereinabove with respect to FIG. **3**, the respective positions and/or orientations between tracking system (units **106.sub.1** and **106.sub.2**) and other helmet-mounted components of system **100**, such as eye position determination module **108**, electro-optical projection module **112**, and optical combiner **114**, are known. Processor **102** provides to electro-optical projection module **112** image **808** that has been corrected (according to embodiments heretofore described), using unified correction data **370** (FIG. **6E**) that takes into account OST aberration correction (see-through corrections), and electro-optical projection module and optical combiner aberrations (display corrections). Projected image **808** at least partially reflected off **810** optical combiner **114** is seen by eye **14** of user in an aligned manner on subject **802** such that an image of hidden object **812** is superimposed on the position of hidden object **804**. Tracking system **106** determines the distance between OST HMD **100** and hidden object **804** so that image of hidden object **812** is correspondingly scaled to match respective dimensions of hidden object **804**.

Tracking system **106** is configured and operative to determine the relative orientation between first

unit **106.sub.1** (associated with optical assembly reference frame **112**) and second unit **106.sub.2** (associated with object reference frame **142**) so that image of hidden object **812** is correspondingly oriented to match the respective orientation of hidden object **804**.

(104) It will be appreciated by persons skilled in the art that the disclosed technique is not limited to what has been particularly shown and described hereinabove. Rather the scope of the disclosed technique is defined only by the claims, which follow.

Claims

1. An optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) system, for viewing an image aligned with an object associated with a first reference frame, the OST HMD system comprising: an electro-optical display device including: at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element for at least one of viewing therethrough said object, and viewing said image; and at least one electro-optical projector configured to irradiate said image for viewing by at least one eye of a user who wears said OST HMD, said electro-optical display device being associated with a second reference frame; and a processor configured to be coupled with said electro-optical display device, said processor configured to generate said image, according to predetermined information, eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, so that said image appears to said user in an aligned manner with respect to said object; wherein said eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye, with respect to said second reference frame; wherein said at least one of orientation, and position and orientation is of said second reference frame with respect to said first reference frame; and wherein said predetermined information relates correction data of said OST HMD to a plurality of different respective position data values of said at least one eyeball feature position; wherein said predetermined information further includes display corrections of said electro-optical display device with respect to said position data values of said at least one eyeball feature position, wherein said predetermined information further includes see-through corrections of said at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element, wherein said predetermined information is attained via a calibration procedure with respect to said plurality of different respective position data, wherein said eyeball feature position data is retrieved from at least one of: (1) an eye position determinator (2) said processor receiving said eyeball feature position data from at least one of: a user, a memory device and a communication module (3) via a user calibration stage.
2. The system according to claim 1, wherein said eye position determinator is configured to determine said at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye with respect to said second reference frame, and to generate corresponding said eyeball feature position data.
3. The system according to claim 2, wherein said eye position determinator includes a camera configured to acquire at least one image of said at least one eye.
4. The system according to claim 2, wherein said eye position determinator and said electro-optical display device are mechanically coupled.
5. The system according to claim 2, wherein said eye position determinator and said electro-optical display device are configured as an on-axis optical arrangement.
6. The system according to claim 2, wherein said determinator is external to said system.
7. The system according to claim 2, wherein said eye position determinator is configured to output said eyeball feature position data in either one of: continuously, and from time to time.
8. The system according to claim 1, further comprising a tracking system configured to determine said at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, of said second reference frame with respect to said first reference frame.
9. The system according to claim 1, further including a memory device for storing said predetermined information, wherein said processor is configured to read said predetermined information from said memory device.

10. The system according to claim 1, wherein in case said at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye does not precisely correspond with one of said plurality of different respective position data values of said predetermined information, said processor is configured to either one of: (1) derive from said correction data closest-matching correction data associated with at least one closest matching position, or (2) derive from said correction data interpolated correction data by interpolating from correction data associated with at least one closest matching position.
11. The system according to claim 1, wherein said OST HMD is used for surgical applications where said object is an anatomical feature.
12. The system according to claim 1, wherein said eyeball feature position data is acquired via said user calibration stage by projecting a user calibration image to said user to be aligned with a real-world object.
13. The system according to claim 1, wherein said predetermined information is stored in a look-up table.
14. A method for irradiating an image in an optical see-through (OST) head mounted display (HMD) for viewing through the OST HMD an object having at least one of a known orientation and a known position and orientation, with respect to a first reference frame, by at least one eye of a user, the method comprising: a calibration procedure for acquiring predetermined information with respect to a plurality of different respective eyeball feature position data; generating and irradiating said image for viewing by said user, via an electro-optical display device, such that said image appears to said user superimposed in an aligned manner with respect to said object, according to said predetermined information, said eyeball feature position data, and at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation; wherein said predetermined information relates correction data of said OST HMD with a plurality of different respective position data values of at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye; wherein said predetermined information further includes display corrections of said electro-optical display device with respect to said position data values of said at least one eyeball feature position, wherein said predetermined information further includes see-through corrections of said at least one partially reflective partially transmissive optical element, wherein said eyeball feature position data is associated with at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye, with respect to a second reference frame; and wherein said at least one of orientation and position and orientation is of said second reference frame with respect to said first reference frame; wherein said eyeball feature position data is retrieved from at least one of: (1) an eye position determinator (2) said processor receiving said eyeball feature position data from at least one of: a user, a memory device and a communication module (3) via a user calibration stage.
15. The method according to claim 14, further comprising generating said eyeball feature position data, by determining corresponding said at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye with respect to said second reference frame.
16. The method according to claim 15, further comprising deriving from said correction data either one of: (1) closest-matching correction data in case determined said at least one eyeball feature position of said at least one eye does not precisely correspond with one of said plurality of different respective position data values of said predetermined information, or (2) interpolated correction data by interpolating from correction data associated with at least one closest matching position.
17. The method according to claim 15, wherein said determining said at least one eyeball feature position and generating and irradiating said image is performed along a common optical axis.
18. The method according to claim 15, wherein said determining said at least one eyeball feature position is performed separately from at least two different spatial positions.
19. The method according to claim 14, further comprising determining said at least one of an orientation, and a position and orientation, of said second reference frame with respect to said first reference frame.
20. The method according to claim 14, further comprising storing said predetermined information.

